FREE · FOR THE WRITERS I WORK WITH

# Copy guides for junior writers

Four short guides to how I write for a brand: the do’s, the don’ts, and prompts you can copy and paste.

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HOW TO PROMPT

# Every prompt has *five lines.*

### Role

Who the AI should be.

**EX:**

Senior conversion copywriter

### Reader

Who it is writing for.

**EX:**

A founder worried about price

### Facts

What it may use. Nothing else.

**EX:**

Your numbers, reviews and notes

### Voice

How it sounds, and what it never says.

**EX:**

Plain and warm. Never “seamless”

### Output

Exactly what to hand back.

**EX:**

5 headlines and 1 call to action

### One line

Gets you an average answer, in an average voice.

### Five lines

Gets you a draft you can actually use.

**HOT TAKE** The prompt is the brief. If a human junior could not write from it, the AI cannot either.

WEBSITE

# Say what changes for the customer. *Then prove it.*

## Landing page

SELLS ONE PROMISE

- **Headline:** the outcome, not the product. The subhead says who it is for.
- **Proof:** a number, a name or a real review, right beside the claim.
- **Benefits:** three at most, in your customer's own words.
- **One ask:** a single button that says what happens next.

## Product description

ANSWERS THE LAST DOUBT

- Open with the benefit, then back it with the fact.
- Answer doubts: size, fit, care, delivery, returns.
- Sensory words beat adjectives. "Soft" beats "premium".
- Check claims with legal. Even famous lines get challenged.

HOT TAKE "Premium", "innovative" and "seamless" are not copy, they are placeholders. When I see one in a draft, I ask what we actually mean.

| DO | DON'T |
| --- | --- |
| The classic · Apple, 2001<br>**"1,000 songs in your pocket."**<br>Same product. One lists the spec, the other describes your life. | The spec sheet<br>**"5GB MP3 player."** |
| Landing page · Airbnb<br>"Belong anywhere." | Landing page<br>"A global marketplace for short-term stays." |

Product page · Apple

“Titanium. So strong. So light. So Pro.”

Product page

“A durable, lightweight titanium frame.”

Product line · Oatly

“It’s like milk, but made for humans.”

Product line

“A plant-based oat beverage alternative.”

## Landing page

```
You are a senior conversion copywriter. Write a
landing page for [PRODUCT].

Reader: [WHO THEY ARE], who is worried about
[OBJECTION].

Use only these facts: [FACTS, NUMBERS, REVIEWS].
If a claim is not backed
by them, flag it instead of writing it.

Voice: [3 ADJECTIVES]. Never use: [BANNED
WORDS].

Give me: 5 headlines that state an outcome, 1
subhead, 3 benefits with
proof, and 1 call to action that says what
happens next.
```

## Product description

```
You are a senior e-commerce copywriter. Write a
product description
for [PRODUCT].

Customer: [WHO], who is choosing between this
and [ALTERNATIVE].
Their biggest doubt: [DOUBT].

Use only these facts: [SPECS, MATERIALS, SIZES,
REVIEWS]. Turn each into
what it means for the customer. Flag anything
you cannot support.

Voice: [3 ADJECTIVES]. Never use: "premium",
"high-quality",
"perfect for any occasion".

Give me: a one-line headline, a 40-word
description, 4 bullets (benefit
first, fact second) and one line that answers
the doubt.
```

> **Not this:** “Write a landing page for my product. Make it catchy and professional.” It gives the model nothing to work with, so you get clichés.

SOCIAL MEDIA

# Win the first line. *The rest only has to keep the promise.*

## Instagram

THREE SECONDS

- **Reels:** put the payoff on screen and out loud, straight away.
- **Captions:** the point goes in the first line. The feed cuts off the rest.
- **Proof:** show the real thing. A face, a number, the product.
- One post, one point. A second takeaway is a second post.

## LinkedIn

A FEW LINES

- **Hook:** a result, a mistake, a contrarian take or a question.
- **Shape:** short lines, one idea each, a blank line between.
- **Story:** the situation, the turn, the lesson.
- **Ending:** one question your reader can answer in a line.

HOT TAKE If your hook could open any brand's post, it is not a hook. Make it so specific that only you could have written it.

| DO | DON'T |
| --- | --- |
| The classic · Oreo, 2013<br>**"You can still dunk in the dark."**<br>It joined the conversation everyone was already having, in one line. | The brand line<br>**"Our cookies are perfect for any occasion."** |
| Instagram · Apple<br>"Shot on iPhone." | Instagram<br>"Check out this amazing photo we took with our incredible camera!" |

Hook · Spotify

“Dear person who played ‘Sorry’ 42 times on Valentine’s Day...”

Hook

“Millions of songs for every mood and moment.”

LinkedIn · shape

Short lines. One idea each. A blank line between.

LinkedIn · shape

One 200-word block that never breaks.

## Draft the post

```
You are a social writer for [BRAND] on Instagram
and LinkedIn.

Reader: [WHO], who is stuck on [PROBLEM].

Angle: [ONE INSIGHT, STORY OR RESULT]. Use only
these notes: [PASTE NOTES].

Voice: [3 ADJECTIVES]. Never use: "excited to
share", "game-changer",
"unlock".

Give me: 5 openers under 12 words, a LinkedIn
post (short lines, under
[180] words, ending on one question) and an
Instagram caption (point in
the first line).
```

## Sharpen the hook

```
Here is my draft post: [PASTE].

Rewrite only the first line 5 ways: a result, a
mistake, a contrarian
take, a question and a specific moment.

Score each from 1 to 5 on: specific, surprising,
would I stop scrolling?

Pick the best and say why in one sentence. Do
not touch the rest.
```

> **Not this:** “Write a LinkedIn post about our new feature.” There is no reader and no angle, so expect “Excited to announce...”.

BRAND VOICE

# A voice is not adjectives. *It is decisions.*

The voice stays the same. The tone shifts with the moment.

### Ask the founder

BEFORE YOU WRITE

- **Beliefs:** start with what they believe and who they serve, not a mood board.
- **Nevers:** ask what they would never say, and who they hate sounding like.
- **Samples:** collect five pieces of copy they are proud of.
- **Specifics:** push past “friendly and professional”.

### Write it down

WHILE YOU WRITE

- **The “not”:** give every trait one. Warm, not chatty.
- **Sentences:** show each trait in a before-and-after line.
- **Hard moments:** plan the error, the apology and the refund.
- **One page:** a new writer should be able to use it today.

> HOT TAKE A brand voice is what you refuse to say. The “nots” do more work than the adjectives.

## The dials

Circle one dot per line. Filled dots show an example answer.




### THEN ASK ABOUT MOMENTS

- How should we sound when a customer is angry?
- When we launch something big?
- When we make a mistake?
- When we explain something complicated?

### SEND THIS TO THE FOUNDER

- If our brand walked into a room, who would it be? Three words.
- What do we believe that our category does not?
- Who do we talk to, and what worries them at 11pm?
- Which brand's voice do you love, and which would you hate to sound like?
- Which words would we never say?

**HOT TAKE** Never accept "somewhere in between". Middle of the road is how a brand ends up sounding like nobody.

## DO

The classic · Mailchimp's voice guide

**"We are plainspoken. We are genuine. Our humor is dry."**

Traits a writer can act on. Each one tells you what to do next.

## DON'T

The usual version

**"We're friendly and professional."**

**Personality · Oatly**

“Yes, we are vegan. So?”

**Personality**

“We are proud to offer plant-based options for conscious consumers.”

**Voice vs tone · Mailchimp**

Same voice every day. A different tone for someone who is upset.

**Voice vs tone**

One tone, everywhere, all the time.

**Many markets**

Same voice, local words: “lift” in London, “elevator” in New York.

**Many markets**

The same copy, translated word for word, in every market.

## Turn the answers into a voice guide

```
You are a brand strategist and senior writer. Here are the founder's
answers: [PASTE] and five pieces of copy they love: [PASTE].

Find the three traits that show up in both. For each trait write: what it
sounds like, "we are X, not Y", a before-and-after sentence, three words
we use and three we avoid.

Then add tone for a launch, an error and an apology.

Quote the founder's own words. Flag any answers that contradict each other.
```

> **Not this:** “Create a tone of voice guide for our brand. We’re friendly and professional.” Every brand says that, so nothing tells a writer what to do.

YOUR VOICE

# You already have a voice. *Notice it, then make it deliberate.*

Read your own writing like an editor who has never met you.

## Notice

STEP ONE

- **Aloud:** read it out. Where you stumble, the sentence is wrong.
- **Length:** count the words in your last five sentences.
- **Tics:** list the words you overuse. “Just”, “really”, “very”.
- **Signature:** find the three lines that sound most like you.

## Edit

STEP TWO

- **Rhythm:** put a short sentence next to a long one.
- **Hedges:** cut “just”, “I think” and the warm-up.
- **Plain words:** if a short word works, use it.
- **Keep:** the habits that sound like you. Break the rest.

HOT TAKE You do not need to “find your voice”. You need to stop sanding it down.

| DO | DON’T |
| --- | --- |
| The classic · Avis, 1962<br>**“We try harder.”**<br>Three words, an honest admission and a promise. Cut until it still sounds like you. | The usual version<br>**“We are committed to continually improving our customer experience.”** |
| Hedges<br>Can we talk Thursday? | Hedges<br>I just wanted to quickly reach out to see if you might have some time to connect. |

Opener

Hi Sam, loved your talk on pricing.

Bio

I write product pages that sell and onboarding emails people finish.

Opener

I hope this email finds you well.

Bio

Passionate marketer with a proven track record of driving results.

ANSWER THESE FIRST

- Read one piece aloud. Where do you stumble?
- Count the words in your last five sentences. Short, long or mixed?
- Do you plan first, or write to find out what you think?
- Which words do you overuse?
- What do you always delete in the edit?
- Whose writing do you copy, on purpose or by accident?

## Let AI read your samples

```
You are an editor who reads for voice, not
grammar. Here are five samples
of my writing: [PASTE]. Do not rewrite them.

Describe my voice: average sentence length,
words and openers I repeat,
how formal I am, how I use questions.

Quote the 3 lines that sound most like me and
the 3 that sound least,
and say why.

Then give me 5 habits to keep and 3 to break.
Evidence over praise.
```

> **Not this:** “Analyse my writing style.” The model guesses, so you get flattery and a list of adjectives.

CHECKLIST

# Before it ships.

## WEBSITE

- [ ] Headline states the outcome
- [ ] Every claim has proof
- [ ] One ask, one clear verb
- [ ] Product details match the product
- [ ] Read aloud: sounds human

## SOCIAL MEDIA

- [ ] First line works alone
- [ ] One idea, nothing extra
- [ ] Cut for the platform
- [ ] Ends on a real question
- [ ] Facts and tags checked

## BRAND VOICE

- [ ] Every trait has a “not”
- [ ] Real before-and-after lines
- [ ] Hard moments planned
- [ ] Fits on one page
- [ ] Founder says “that’s us”

## YOUR VOICE

- [ ] Read aloud, no stumbles
- [ ] Short next to long
- [ ] Hedges and filler cut
- [ ] Still sounds like you
- [ ] Cut the first line: still works?

> **HOT TAKE** AI can draft it. Only a person can check it. Every fact, price and claim gets read by a human.

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Written for the writers on my team, and free for anyone else who wants it. Mehr Patni, Dubai.